



BatonIndex

Leadership Succession Intelligence

A RESEARCH BRIEF FOR SEARCH PROFESSIONALS

The Discipline Behind the Dean

Who actually leads America's research business schools, and how the path to the corner office is changing.

795

dean appointments

152

Carnegie R1 universities

1990-2025

36 years

The Discipline Behind the Dean

Search committees and their advisors tend to picture the business-school deanship as the property of finance and strategy. A population-scale census says otherwise. BatonIndex analyzed a hand-coded, web-verified record of **795 dean appointments at all 152 Carnegie R1 universities from 1990 to 2025**, classifying every dean's discipline individually. The result is a map of which fields actually reach the corner office, how they get there, and how the market is shifting, with direct consequences for sourcing, benchmarking, and advising.

Six findings

- **Discipline shapes the odds.** Operations management is the single most over-represented field in the deanship relative to its faculty size (a 1.38 representation ratio), while marketing and information systems supply fewer deans than their bench implies.
- **Operations is a durable pipeline, not a novelty.** OM has held a stable 9-12% of appointments in every era for four decades, including at Harvard, Wharton, Booth, Columbia, MIT Sloan, and Darden.
- **The office is turning over faster and broadening.** Interim appointments rose from 18% to 38%; the female share from 1.2% to 31.4%; and permanent-dean tenures are compressing.
- **Interim seats skew operational.** An operations-trained candidate is roughly twice as likely to be appointed on an interim basis (44% vs. a 31% average).
- **Deans are grown at home.** Half of all R1 deans are internal promotions, 62% for operations, and the pipeline tracks a school's own faculty and its regional economy.
- **The gender gap is discipline-specific.** Operations converts its senior women into deans at roughly one-third the expected rate (a 0.38 promotion ratio), the lowest of any business discipline.

HOW TO USE THIS BRIEF

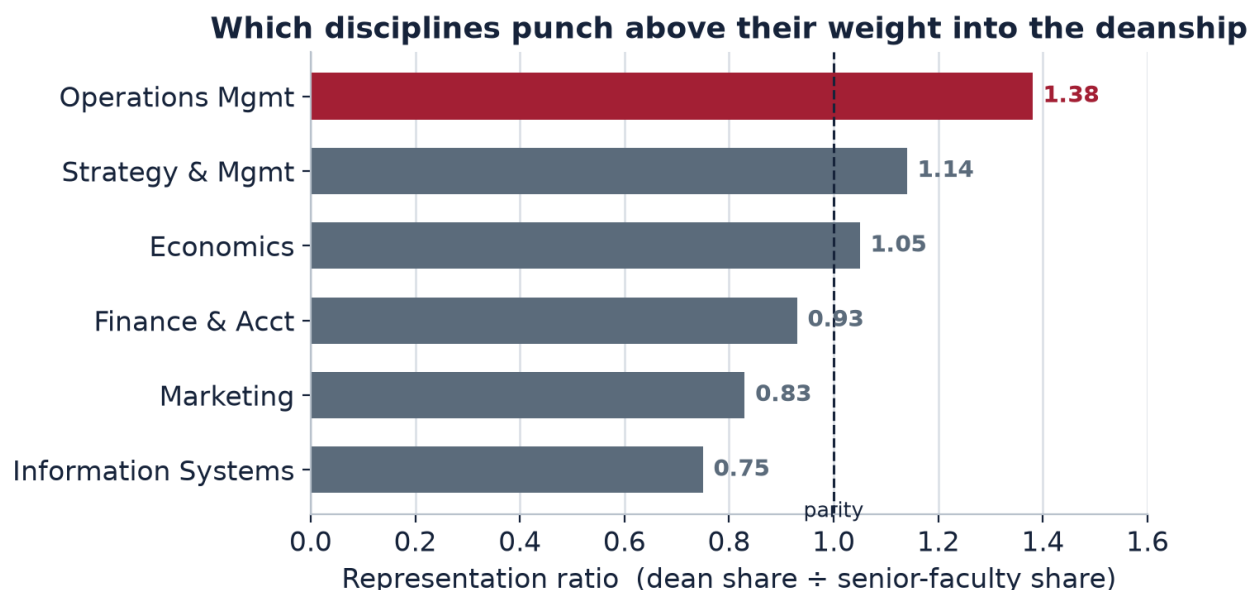
Each finding pairs the evidence with an implication for the search room, where to source, how to read a slate, and which assumptions about the pipeline no longer hold.

Discipline & the pipeline

Discipline shapes the odds of reaching the deanship

Benchmarked against the disciplines' share of senior business faculty, the paths to the deanship are uneven. Operations management holds **10.3% of dean appointments while supplying just 7.4% of full professors, a representation ratio of 1.38**, and the only discipline whose over-representation survives a multiple-testing correction.

At the other end, **information systems (0.75) and marketing (0.83)** send fewer of their senior faculty to the corner office than their size would predict. Finance and accounting, despite their reputation, sit essentially at parity (0.93). Where a candidate trained is not a neutral fact, it shifts the odds.



Representation ratio by discipline, dean share divided by senior-faculty share; 1.00 is parity. R1 census, 1990-2025.

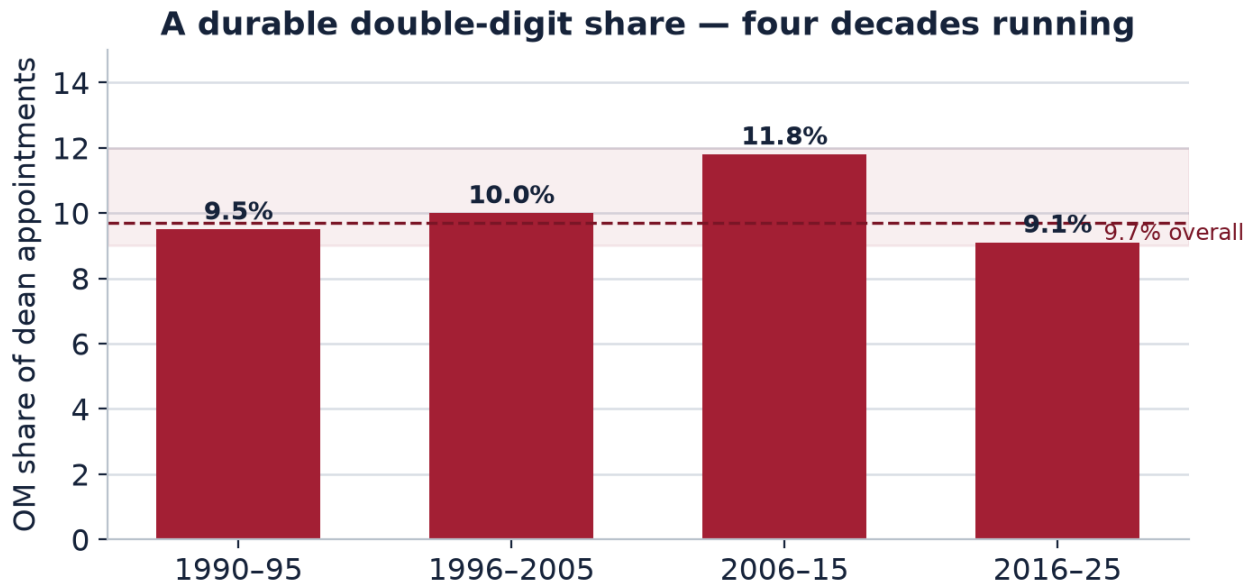
FOR SEARCH LEADERS

Don't assume finance and strategy own the pipeline. Operations is a live, under-shopped pool of proven administrators; IS and marketing supply fewer deans than their bench size suggests. Factor the base rates into where you fish before you build the slate.

A durable pipeline**Operations is a proven route, not a fad**

The operations presence is not a recent blip. OM accounts for **9.7% of all 795 appointments (77 deans)**, and the share has stayed in a tight **9-12% band in every era since 1990**, neither rising nor eroding as appointment volume tripled.

These are not marginal schools. Operations-trained scholars have led **Harvard Business School, Wharton, Chicago Booth, Columbia, Cornell Johnson, MIT Sloan, UCLA Anderson, Texas McCombs, and UVA Darden**. For four decades, roughly one dean in ten has come from a field long imagined to be peripheral to leadership.



OM share of dean appointments by era; shaded band marks the paper's stated 9-12% range.

FOR SEARCH LEADERS

An operations background is a credible, four-decade-proven route to the deanship, not a wildcard. When a committee anchors on the usual finance and strategy names, a well-framed operations leader is a defensible, differentiated addition to the slate.

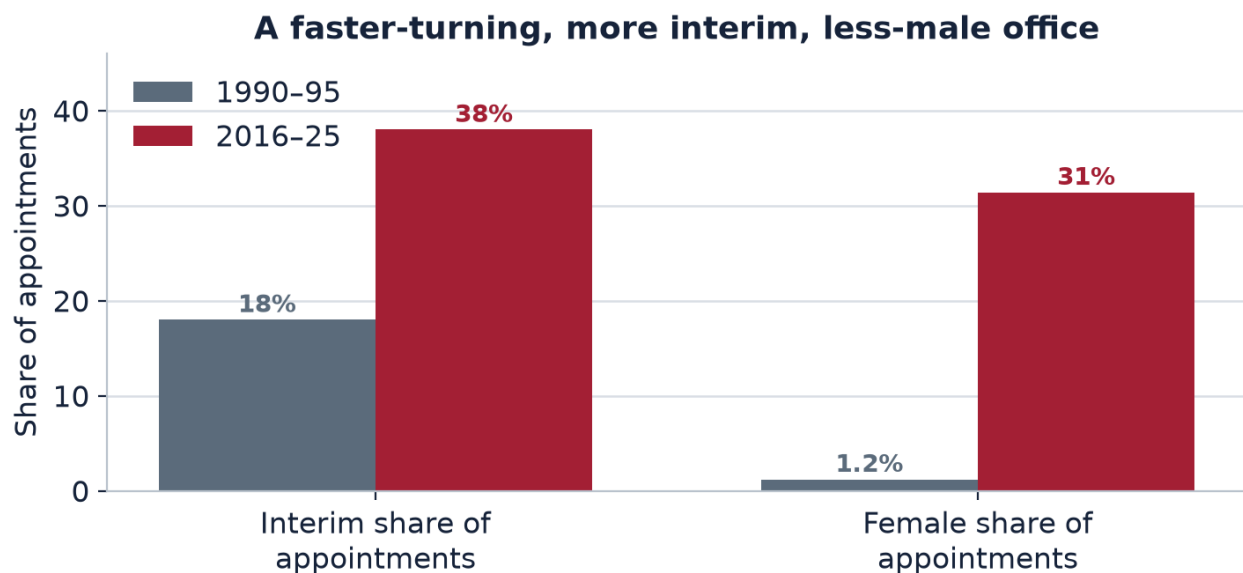
FINDING 3 OF 6

The changing market

The market is busier, more interim, and broader

The office itself is changing under everyone's feet. Appointment volume rose from **80 to 283 per era**, and the number of appointment events per active school climbed from 1.25 to 2.13, schools change deans more often. The **interim share grew from 18% to 38%**, and the **female share from 1.2% to 31.4%**.

Permanent-dean tenures are compressing at the same time. The net effect is a faster-turning market with a wider, more female candidate field and a heavier reliance on interim stewardship than a decade ago.



Interim and female share of appointments, first era (1990-95) vs. last (2016-25).

FOR SEARCH LEADERS

Plan for more searches, more interim mandates, and a broader candidate field than the last cycle. Comps and expectations built on a 2010 market will understate both turnover and the diversity of who is now in play.

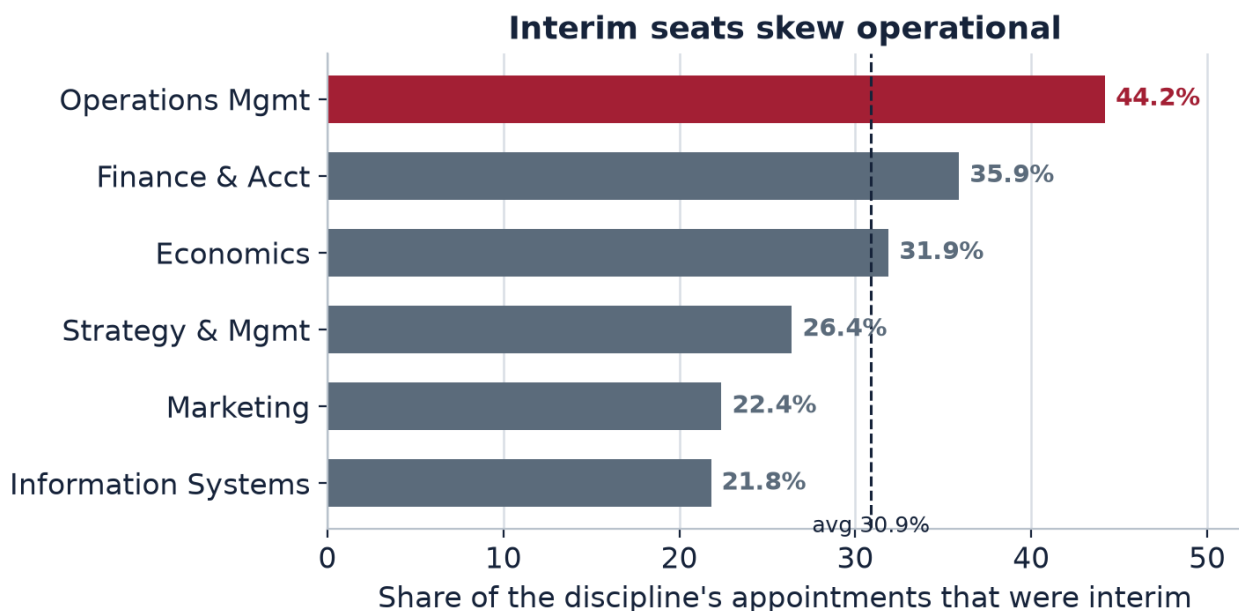
Interim stewardship

Interim seats skew operational

When a school needs the machine kept running rather than repositioned, it reaches for operators.

44% of operations appointments are interim, against a 31% average and just 22% for information systems, the ordering runs monotonically from the most to the least operational discipline. Controlling for year and public status, an OM candidate is **nearly twice as likely** to be appointed on an interim basis (odds ratio ~1.9).

The paper is careful that this admits several readings, genuine fit for continuity work, a service norm, or incomplete access that doesn't convert to permanent at the same rate. For a recruiter, all three matter.



Interim share of appointments by discipline; dashed line is the 30.9% overall average.

FOR SEARCH LEADERS

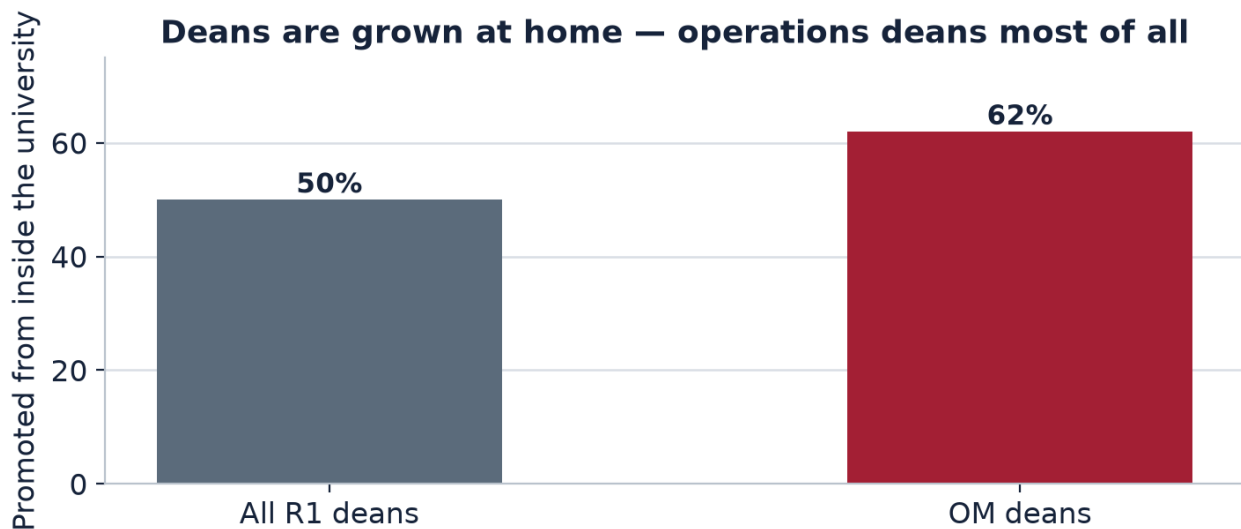
For continuity or caretaker mandates, operators are the natural pool. But watch conversion: an interim operator may be a tryout that never converts. Clarify the path to permanent up front so a strong candidate isn't parked in a seat that quietly caps their trajectory.

Where deans come from

Deans are grown at home

The pipeline is built locally. **Half of all R1 deans are internal promotions; for operations it is 62%.** Operations leaders reach the office less as externally recruited stars than as trusted internal colleagues already embedded in the school's administrative machinery.

That local bench is, in turn, shaped by geography: a school's operations faculty is larger where its home-state economy is operations-intensive, manufacturing, logistics, wholesale, and the pattern is concentrated at publicly embedded universities. Supply is not evenly distributed across the map.



Share of appointments filled by internal promotion: all R1 deans vs. OM deans.

FOR SEARCH LEADERS

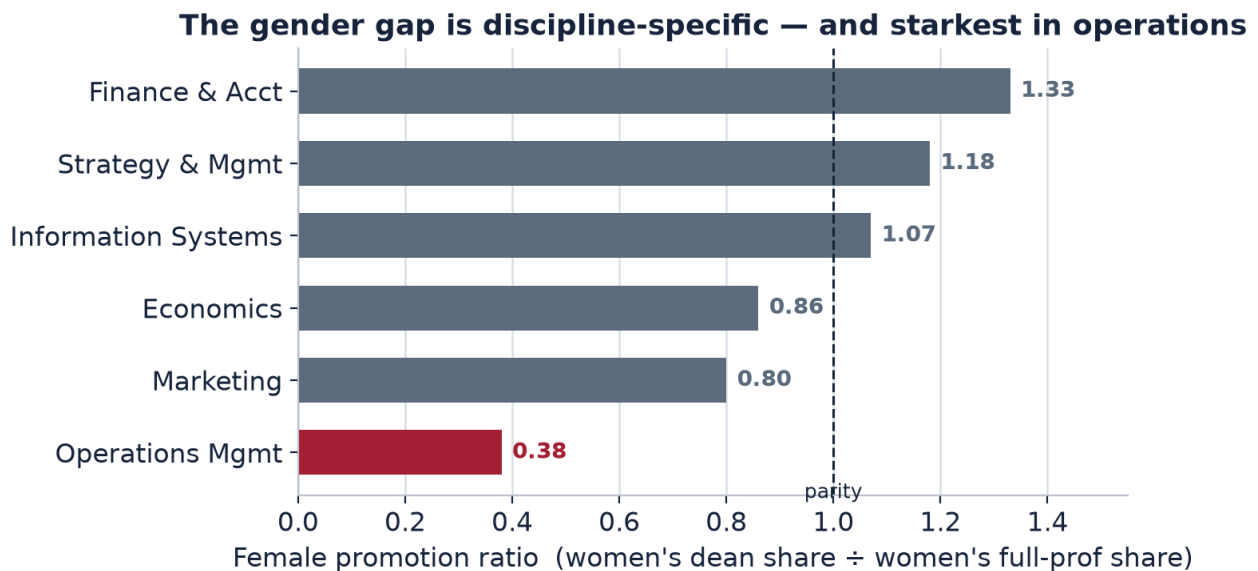
Take internal candidates seriously, a courtesy internal look misses where much of this talent sits. And read regional supply: a school in an industrial state likely has a deeper operations bench to promote from than a coastal peer, which shapes both the internal field and realistic external comps.

The gender constraint

The gender gap is discipline-specific, starkest in operations

Female candidate depth is not uniform across fields, and the sharpest deficit is in operations. Of 77 OM appointments, **only five went to women, four of them interim**, a 6.5% share against a 17% female full-professor pool. The resulting **promotion ratio of 0.38 is the lowest of any business discipline**, and OM is the only field that fails a test against its own senior-women supply.

Other disciplines clear the bar: finance and accounting (1.33) and strategy (1.18) actually convert women into deans above parity. The gap is a discipline story, not a universal one, and there are signs of movement: in 2026 Chapman and UVA Darden (its first woman dean in seventy years) both appointed women operations scholars to permanent roles.



Female promotion ratio by discipline, women's dean share divided by women's full-prof share; 1.00 is parity.

FOR SEARCH LEADERS

The supply of senior women exists; the conversion is what lags, most steeply in operations. Put qualified female candidates on the initial slate by default, and press clients to track the associate-dean feeder by gender. This is the clearest place a committee can widen a stalled search.

What this means for your next search

Six evidence-based moves for committees and recruiters working the dean market:

- **Widen the discipline lens.** Operations and other quantitative fields supply more deans than their reputation suggests, don't pre-filter the pipeline to finance and strategy.
- **Frame operations candidates with the base rate.** A four-decade, 9-12% track record makes an OM leader a defensible, differentiated slate addition, not a wildcard.
- **Staff for a busier market.** More searches, more interims, shorter tenures, plan capacity and set client expectations accordingly.
- **Guard the interim path.** For continuity mandates, operators fit, but secure an explicit route to permanent so a tryout doesn't become a ceiling.
- **Mine the internal bench.** Half of deans are internal; the regional economy shapes where the deepest benches sit.
- **Close the discipline-specific gender gap.** Female depth varies by field; in operations especially, default qualified women onto the initial slate and track the feeder.

About this brief

This brief distills a BatonIndex working paper, *“Operations Management as a Leadership Pipeline for US Business Schools (1990-2025).”* The evidence is a hand-coded census of **795 dean appointments (552 permanent, 243 interim) at all 152 Carnegie R1 universities**, 1990-2025, with each dean's discipline classified individually from doctoral field, pre-deanship faculty appointment, and published scholarly identity. Appointments were assembled from primary sources, university announcements, official biographies and CVs, departmental pages, and contemporaneous coverage, and passed a full web-verification pass in 2026. Faculty benchmarks come from AACSB's Business School Data Guide; representation and promotion ratios, interim shares, and hiring-origin figures are drawn directly from the paper's reported statistics.

BatonIndex maintains leadership-succession intelligence on more than 10,000 academic leaders across twelve role families, business, medical, law, nursing, pharmacy, education, agriculture, public health, arts & sciences deans, provosts, and presidents, with sourced education histories, career pathways, and live appointment tracking. This brief is one view into that data.

PUT THE DATA TO WORK

Want the underlying benchmarks for a specific school, discipline, or region, or a co-branded edition of this brief for a client? Reach the BatonIndex team through the Contact link in the app.

Suggested citation: BatonIndex (2026). The Discipline Behind the Dean: A Research Brief. Based on the working paper “Operations Management as a Leadership Pipeline for US Business Schools (1990-2025).”